

2025 Qatar Investment Climate Statement

Executive Summary

Qatar is one of the world's largest liquefied natural gas (LNG) exporters and has one of the highest per capita incomes. In 2023, Qatar's gross domestic product (GDP) reached \$194 billion, a 2 percent annual increase owing to higher hydrocarbon sales. The International Monetary Fund (IMF) projects a 1.5-1.9 percent GDP annual increase in 2024-2025, driven by QatarEnergy's plans to increase LNG production by over 85 percent, with new capacity expected to come online in 2026-2027. The government projects a \$3.6 billion budget deficit in 2025, based on a \$60 per barrel oil price assumption. In the long term, Qatar forecasts an average annual GDP growth rate of 4 percent between 2026 and 2030, driven primarily by LNG production expansion.

The government remains the dominant economic actor but encourages private and foreign direct investment (FDI), particularly in line with National Vision 2030 and the third National Development Strategy 2024-2030. The latter aims to attract \$100 billion in inward FDI by 2030. Reforms in 2018-2020 allow up to 100 percent foreign ownership in most sectors, including real estate in designated areas. Significant opportunities exist in,

- Infrastructure,
- Healthcare,
- Education,
- Tourism,
- Energy,
- Information and communications technology (ICT), and
- Services.

Key sectors attracting FDI include:

- Manufacturing,
- Mining and quarrying,
- Finance, and
- Insurance.

Incentives include temporary customs duty exemptions and land-use benefits. The corporate tax rate is 10 percent, except for a 35 percent tax on foreign firms in extractive industries.

The government has created agencies like the Administrative Control and Transparency Authority, the National Competition Protection Authority, and the Anti-Monopoly Committee to curb corruption and anti-competitive practices. An online portal for government tenders was introduced in 2016 to improve transparency, although personal connections reportedly still play a significant role in business deals. The Qatari government has improved human trafficking legislation, addressed forced labor, and set a minimum wage but faces issues such as slow labor dispute resolution, restrictions on expression and assembly, and forced labor cases. In 2024, the government enacted a law requiring the private sector to hire more Qatari citizens. U.S. companies in Qatar have expressed concerns about their ability to meet the legal requirement due to Qatari citizens' strong preference for working in the public sector, leading to potential fines and perception of increased difficulty of doing business.

Qatar has increased its U.S. investments through the Qatar Investment Authority (QIA) and its subsidiaries, notably its real estate subsidiary, Qatari Diar. QIA opened an office in New York City in 2015. The U.S.-Qatar Strategic Dialogue, currently in its seventh iteration, further strengthens strategic and economic partnerships and addresses investment and trade obstacles.

Section 1. Openness to, and Restrictions upon, Foreign Investment

Policies toward Foreign Direct Investment

In recent years, the Government of Qatar enacted reforms to incentivize and attract FDI. Key FDI-friendly legislation includes Law 1/2019 (Foreign Direct Investment Law), which permits full

foreign ownership in most economic sectors; Law 16/2018 (Foreign Real Estate Ownership Law), which regulates foreign real estate investment and ownership; and Law 12/2020, which regulates public-private partnerships. In 2019, the Ministry of Commerce and Industry (MOCI) established the Investment Promotion Agency-Qatar to further attract inward FDI. Other bodies facilitating FDI include:

- The Qatar Financial Centre,
- Qatar Science and Technology Park, and
- The Qatar Free Zones Authority,
- All of which offer full foreign ownership,
- Repatriation of profits,
- Tax incentives, and
- Investment funds for small and medium-sized enterprises.

The Qatari government's economic spending plans are expected to create opportunities for foreign investors. For 2025, the government allocated nearly \$17 billion for major projects. The budget includes \$5.3 billion for education, \$6 billion for health, and \$6 billion in municipal spending. The budget emphasizes private sector roles and public-private partnerships. The government plans to nearly double its LNG production, its primary source of revenue, from 77 to 142 million metric tons per year before the end of 2030, offering significant investment opportunities in upstream and downstream sectors. Qatar's third National Development Strategy, for 2024-2030, aims to diversify the economy through FDI, targeting \$100 billion in inward FDI and reducing business registration time to one day.

The Government of Qatar extends preferential treatment to suppliers using local content in government contract bids. Tenders valued at five million Qatari riyals (\$1.37 million) or less are limited to local small- and medium-sized enterprises. Higher-value tenders theoretically do not require any local commercial registration, but exceptions exist.

Qatar maintains ongoing dialogue with the United States through official and private sector tracks, including the annual U.S.-Qatar Strategic Dialogue, official trade missions, and institutional relationships between U.S. and Qatari government agencies. Qatari officials emphasize a desire to increase American investments in Qatar and Qatari investments in the United States.

Limits on Foreign Control and Right to Private Ownership and Establishment

Law 1/2019 on Regulating the Investment of Non-Qatari Capital in Economic Activity (replacing Law 13/2000) allows foreign investors to invest in Qatar by partnering with a Qatari investor owning 51 percent or more of the enterprise or by applying to MOCI for up to 100 percent foreign ownership. However, not all sectors are open to foreign investment. Law 1/2019 limits new foreign ownership to 49 percent in the insurance sector and commercial agencies, barring special Cabinet dispensation. Some sectors, such as telecommunications, are monopolized by local state-owned enterprises and are closed to competition. Ministerial Decision 44/2020 outlines regulations related to the FDI law.

Law 16/2018 permits foreign individuals, companies, and real estate developers to own property in Qatar; however, Cabinet Decision No. 28 of 2020 restricts full ownership to nine designated zones. In 16 additional zones, foreigners may not own property outright but may obtain long-term usage rights—known as usufruct—for up to 99 years. This arrangement allows them to use, develop, or lease the property during the agreed period, while ownership remains with the original titleholder. Foreigners may also own properties within selected residential complexes and retail outlets in specific commercial complexes. Foreign real estate investors and owners are eligible for residency in Qatar for as long as they own their property, provided they reside in Qatar for a minimum of 90 days a year. The minimum value of property for usufructuary rights is 730,000 Qatari riyals (\$200,522) while the value of property for freehold ownership is \$1 million (3.65 million Qatari riyals). The Cabinet created the Office for Non-Qatari Real Estate Ownership in 2020 to regulate foreign real estate ownership and use. The Invest in Qatar Center within MOCI vets full foreign ownership applications. Establishing a legal presence is required to conduct business in Qatar.

Law 12/2024 on the Qatarization of Jobs in the Private Sector dictates that the Ministry of Labor (MOL) may identify certain jobs exclusive to Qatari citizens or children of Qatari women within the private sector. Employers found in breach of this law may face up to three years imprisonment and a fine of up to one million Qatari riyals (\$274,725). Foreign investors wishing to operate wholly owned companies in Qatar are required to submit a workforce localization plan. The third National Development Strategy targets a 20 percent Qatari workforce in private and semi-private sectors by 2030. U.S. companies in Qatar have expressed concerns about their ability to meet the legal requirement. Companies have reported difficulties recruiting Qatari citizens in private sector jobs due to Qataris' strong preference for working in the government. In 2020, the cabinet issued a decision mandating that Qataris make up 80 percent of human resource offices and at least 60 percent of overall employees in state-owned enterprises or in companies in which the government holds a majority stake.

U.S. investors and companies are not disadvantaged more than other foreign investors by ownership or control mechanisms, sector restrictions, or investment screening. However, wholly owned U.S. companies have reported difficulties in establishing local bank accounts to pay employees. Some administrative requirements for launching a business have not caught up with recent foreign ownership regulation adjustments, creating bureaucratic hurdles for fully foreign-owned companies.

Other Investment Policy Reviews

Qatar underwent a [World Trade Organization \(WTO\) Trade Policy Review in April 2021](#).

Business Facilitation

Qatar participates in the WTO's Joint Initiative on Investment Facilitation for Development. Local reforms have streamlined the commercial registration process. Local and foreign investors can apply for a commercial license through MOCI's one-stop-shop or online via [the single window portal](#). Per Law 1/2019, the Ministry will issue a decision within 15 days of receiving a complete application for establishing a foreign-owned company. Rejected applications can be resubmitted or appealed. Upon approval, registering a small limited liability

company in Qatar takes eight to nine days. In September 2024, MOCI announced that it reduced the cost of business registration by 90 percent for both domestic and foreign investors, to lower barriers to doing business.

Domestic and foreign companies may also opt to register in one of Qatar's economic zones:

- [Qatar Financial Centre](#)
- [Qatar Free Zones Authority](#)
- [Qatar Science and Technology Park](#)

The Investment Promotion Agency Qatar ([Invest Qatar](#)), established in 2019, also provides services for connecting with local business partners and identifying opportunities for foreign investors across Qatar's economic sectors.

Outward Investment

Qatar does not restrict domestic investors from investing abroad. According to the World Bank, Qatar's outward foreign investment net outflows reached \$2.38 billion in 2022. The main sectors for Qatar's outward FDI are finance and insurance, transportation, storage, information and communication, and mining and quarrying. Qatar also holds significant foreign investments in real estate and hospitality. Per the latest publicly available outward FDI survey (2018), Qatari investment firms held investments in over 80 countries, with the top destinations being the European Union, the Gulf Cooperation Council, and other Arab countries.

Section 2. Investment and Taxation Treaties

[Qatar is party to 32 bilateral investment treaties \(BITs\) currently in force](#), according to the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD). While Qatar has not entered a bilateral investment or free trade agreement with the United States, the two countries established a Trade and Investment Framework Agreement (TIFA) in 2004. Additionally, as part of the GCC, Qatar has signed 12 treaties with investment provisions (TIPs), including:

- The 2012 U.S.-GCC Framework Agreement on Trade,

- Economic,
- Investment, and
- Technical Cooperation, which has not entered into force.

Qatar does not have a bilateral taxation treaty with the United States.

Section 3. Legal Regime

Transparency of the Regulatory System

Qatar has taken steps to protect competition and encourage private investment. While the World Trade Organization recognizes progress in developing Qatar's legal and institutional framework, it also notes gaps in regulatory transparency and public consultation. In addition to the National Competition Protection and Anti-Monopoly Committee, regulatory authorities monitor economic activity and ensure fair practices in most sectors. However, Qatar lacks a transparent rulemaking mechanism, according to the World Bank's Global Indicators of Regulatory Governance.

Government ministries and regulatory agencies do not share regulatory plans or publish draft laws for public consideration. Qatar lacks a formal public consultation process. The 45-member Shura Council (30 of whom are publicly elected) reviews draft legislation and provides advisory opinions, which the Cabinet may consider before submitting legislation to the Amir for final approval. The text of all legislation is published online and in local newspapers upon the Amir's approval. All Qatari laws are issued in Arabic in [Qatar's official legal portal](#) (not necessarily accessible outside Qatar) and eventually translated to English. Qatar-based legal firms provide translations to their clients. Each approved law defines and tasks one or more government entities with implementation and enforcement.

MOCI is Qatar's primary commercial regulator. The Commercial Companies' Law 11/2015 and its amended articles in Law 8/2021 require publicly traded companies to submit financial statements to the Ministry in compliance with International Financial Reporting Standards (IFRS) and the International Accounting Standards (IAS). Publicly listed companies must also

publish financial statements at least 15 days before annual general meetings in two local newspapers (in Arabic and English) and on their websites. All companies must prepare accounting records according to standards set by the IAS Board.

The Qatar Central Bank (QCB) is the primary financial regulator overseeing all financial institutions in Qatar, per Law 13/2012, which established a Financial Stability and Risk Control Committee headed by the QCB Governor. According to Law 7/2005, the Qatar Financial Centre Regulatory Authority (QFCRA) is the independent regulator of firms and individuals conducting financial services in or from the Qatar Financial Centre. The QCB also oversees financial markets within QFC (see [QFCRA regulations](#)).

The Government of Qatar is transparent about its public finances and debt obligations. [QCB publishes quarterly banking data](#), including external government debt, government bonds, treasury bills, and Sukuk (Islamic bonds).

International Regulatory Considerations

Qatar is a member of the Gulf Cooperation Council (GCC), a political and economic regional bloc. Laws based on GCC regulations must be approved through Qatar's domestic legislative process and reviewed by the Qatari Cabinet and the Shura Council before implementation. Qatar has been a member of the World Trade Organization (WTO) since 1996 and usually notifies its draft technical regulations to the WTO Committee on Technical Barriers to Trade (TBT). Qatar is also a member of the Arab League (AL) and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC), both of which promote cooperation and coordination among member states, including in economic matters.

Legal System and Judicial Independence

Qatar's legal system is based on civil and Islamic Sharia laws. Qatar's constitution takes precedence over all laws, followed by decrees and ministerial decisions. The Supreme Judicial Council established under Law 10/2003 appoints all judges, oversees Qatari courts, and functions independently from the executive branch. Qatari courts adjudicate civil and commercial disputes per civil and Sharia laws. International agreements have equal status with

Qatari laws, and the Constitution ensures that international pacts, treaties, and agreements to which Qatar is party are respected. Contract enforcement is governed by the Civil Code Law 22/2004.

State-owned enterprises and government-run institutions may receive favorable treatment and special consideration when bidding for government contracts if they incorporate local value components into their proposals. The Qatar Investment Authority (QIA), the nation's sovereign wealth fund, may be granted priority in investment opportunities and regulatory exemptions due to its contribution to Qatar's economic growth and diversification. Other flagship companies may access government funds and regulatory support to ensure stability and effectiveness within vital sectors. Alongside support for state-owned companies, the Qatari government actively promotes foreign investments in the private sector, pursuant to the Foreign Investment Law 1/2019, which offers incentives to foreign investors.

Law 21/2021 established an Investment and Commerce Court to oversee commercial disputes. Decisions can be appealed before the Court of Appeals or the Court of Cassation. Law 20/2021 on Mediation in the Settlement of Civil and Commercial Disputes applies when parties agree to mediate and settle disputes. Companies registered with MOCI are subject to Qatari courts and laws, primarily the Commercial Companies Law 11/2015, with amendments in Law 8/2021. The QFC operates under a separate legal framework based on English common law, applicable only to QFC-licensed companies. Criminal matters remain under the jurisdiction of Qatar's national legal system. Similarly, companies registered with the Qatar Free Zones Authority are governed by specialized regulations. Law 15/2021 amends the Free Zones Law 34/2005, further protecting registered companies from unlawful license revocations.

Laws and Regulations on Foreign Direct Investment

Law 1/2019 on Regulating the Investment of Non-Qatari Capital in Economic Activity and Law 16/2018 on Regulating Non-Qatari Ownership and Use of Properties aims to encourage greater foreign investment by authorizing, incentivizing, and protecting foreign ownership. MOCI is Qatar's main investment registration body. It gives preference to investments that add value to the local economy and align with the country's national development plans. It has a physical

“one-stop-shop” and an online portal. Different laws and regulations govern FDI at the [Qatar Financial Centre](#), the [Qatar Free Zones Authority](#), and the [Qatar Science and Technology Park](#).

Competition and Antitrust Laws

Law 19/2006 for the Protection of Competition and Prevention of Monopolistic Practice established the Competition Protection and Anti-Monopoly Committee to receive complaints about anti-competition violations. The law protects against monopolistic behavior by entities outside the state if deemed to impact the Qatari market and allows state institutions and government-owned companies absolute or predominant roles in some sectors. Specific sectors, such as public transportation and fuel distribution and marketing, are not open for domestic or foreign competition, with semi-public companies maintaining a predominant role.

Expropriation and Compensation

Under current legislation (Law 1/2019 and Law 16/2018), the government protects foreign investment and property from direct or indirect expropriation, unless for public benefit, in a non-discriminatory manner, and with adequate compensation. Law 8/2022 covers the rules of expropriation for public benefit. The same procedures are applied to the expropriated property of Qatari citizens. Expropriation is unlikely to occur in the investment zones where foreigners may purchase or obtain rights to property. However, the law does not restrict the expropriation power in these areas. The Cabinet approved one expropriation decision between 2023-2024.

Dispute Settlement

ICSID Convention and New York Convention

Qatar has been a party to the 1958 New York Convention since 2011 and a member of the International Centre for Settlement of Investment Disputes (ICSID) since 2002. Qatar enforces foreign arbitral decisions concluded in states party to the New York Convention.

Investor-State Dispute Settlement

The government accepts binding international arbitration of investment disputes. Qatari courts enforce foreign arbitral awards under the New York Convention, though they generally do not enforce foreign court judgments in disputes governed by foreign legal proceedings. According to the United Nations Conference on Trade and Development, Qatar was involved in 12 investment disputes, nine initiated by Qatari investors against foreign governments, and three as the respondent State. Three disputes have been discontinued, and the remaining nine are ongoing.

International Commercial Arbitration and Foreign Courts

The Qatar Financial Centre has an Alternative Dispute Resolution Center, primarily for commercial matters within the QFC, but it can accept other disputes. The Qatar International Court and Dispute Resolution Center handles disputes involving QFC firms under English common law. Qatar's arbitration law (Law 2/2017), based on the United Nations Commission on International Trade Law, grants the QICDRC the jurisdiction over arbitration cases in Qatar. The duration of dispute resolution varies by case (see [past QICDRC judgments](#)). U.S. firms should consult with a Qatari or foreign-based law firms when contracting with local parties.

Bankruptcy and Insolvency Regulations

Qatar has two bankruptcy regimes. The first, under Commercial Law 27/2006 (Articles 606-846), protects creditors from debtors with insufficient assets. The government may act as guarantor to support domestic businesses and safeguard creditors' rights. Bankruptcy can lead to imprisonment, with the sentence length depending on violations like record concealment, embezzlement, or contributing to insolvency. The second regime, under QFC's Insolvency Regulations of 2005, applies to corporate bodies and branches registered in the QFC. Some local firms offer full dissolution services to QFC-registered companies. The Qatar Central Bank (QCB) established the Qatar Credit Bureau in 2010 to promote credit growth. The Bureau provides a centralized credit database to inform policies and support risk management as outlined in the Basel II Accord.

Section 4. Industrial Policies

Investment Incentives

Qatar does not impose a personal income tax but applies a 10 percent corporate tax on most foreign-owned businesses and some self-employed service providers, a 35 percent tax for energy sector companies, and 5 percent withholding tax on payments to non-residents. Majority-owned Qatari firms and self-employed Qataris are exempt from corporate tax. To promote private sector development, the government offers incentives such as subsidies, tax exemptions, and incubation facilities. The Foreign Investment Law (Law 1/2019) provides various incentives to foreign investors, including:

- Exemption from 10 percent corporate tax for up to 10 years.
- Exemption from customs duties on necessary machinery and equipment.
- Exemption from customs duties on raw materials or half-manufactured goods not available locally.
- Preferential utility prices.
- Up to 100 percent foreign ownership and no limit on capital repatriation.

The Qatar Free Zones Authority offers incentives for industrial projects in designated zones, including:

- Exemption from 10 percent corporate tax for up to 20 years.
- Zero custom duties on imports.
- Potential access to government-backed investment funds.
- 100 percent foreign ownership and no limit on capital repatriation.
- Opportunities for joint ventures with local companies.

QatarEnergy determines foreign equity and incentives for industrial energy-related projects, regulated by Law 8/2018. Law 18/2024 promulgates the Unified Industrial Regulatory Law of

GCC, aiming to standardize industrial policies across the GCC and enhance regional cooperation, potentially easing the burden of industrial projects.

Foreign Trade Zones/Free Ports/Trade Facilitation

Qatar has several free zones and business facilitation options:

- **Qatar Financial Centre:** An onshore platform allowing international financial institutions and professional service companies to establish offices with 100 percent foreign ownership and full profit repatriation. Locally sourced profits are subject to a 10 percent corporate tax. The QFC has an independent regulatory regime based on English common law, with the QFC Regulatory Authority overseeing financial firms. The QFC Regulatory Tribunal and Qatar International Court adjudicate cases enforceable by Qatari courts.
- **The Qatar Science and Technology Park:** A hub for research, development, and technology transfer, offering grants and incubators to innovators. Licensed foreign companies can own 100 percent of their projects and fully repatriate capital and income. Companies can import goods and services duty-free and export goods tax-free. Firms can be exempt from all taxes, including the 10 percent corporate tax. Real property cannot be seized, but capital and cash may be seized by court order.
- **The Qatar Free Zones Authority:** Oversees Ras Bufontas and Umm Alhoul, offering 100 percent foreign ownership, corporate tax exemption for up to 20 years, full profit repatriation, and custom duties exemption on imports.
- **Al Afja Area for Recycling Industries, Mesaieed Industrial Zone:** Established in 2019 for recycling and waste management activities, Al Afja offers opportunities for public-private partnerships and private sector startups.

Law 12/2020 on Organizing the Partnership between the Public and Private Sector aims to attract foreign investors and develop the private sector.

Performance and Data Localization Requirements

Law 12/2024, published in October 2024, obligates the private sector, except companies affiliated with QatarEnergy, to hire Qatari nationals in jobs designated by the MOL as exclusive for Qatari nationals or non-Qatari children of Qatari women. Violations can result in up to three years imprisonment and fines up to one million Qatari riyals (\$274,725). The public sector and institutions working closely with the government on projects and joint ventures must hire Qatari nationals. Workforce localization (also known as Qatarization) is central to the third National Development Strategy and National Vision 2030. Foreign investors must submit a Qatarization plan to operate wholly owned companies. A 2020 draft law mandates that Qataris make up at least 60 percent of employees in state-owned enterprises and 80 percent in their human resource offices; this law is pending approval.

Qatar does not enforce a commercial localization policy but gives preferential treatment to suppliers using local content in government bids, including a 10 percent price preference for Qatar-produced goods. Cabinet Decision 11/2022 limits government tenders under five million Qatari riyals (approximately \$1.37 million) to local small- and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs). Higher value tenders do not require local registration, although exceptions exist. QatarEnergy's industry-specific localization initiative (*Tawteen*) requires suppliers and bidders to undergo third-party assessments for In-Country Value (ICV) scores, which are considered alongside technical and commercial criteria (see the [ICV formula](#)).

No specific performance requirements exist for foreign investment in Qatar. Financial and employment data disclosure is required, but proprietary information is not. There are no formal requirements for foreign IT providers to turn over source code or provide surveillance access. Cross-border data transmission is allowed under the law. The Communications Regulatory Authority (CRA), established by Amiri Decree 42/2014, regulates the ICT sector. CRA's Cloud Policy Framework issued in 2022 does not require companies to store data locally. Qatar's Data Protection Law 13/2016 requires companies comply with personal data restrictions, including applying for permission to process sensitive or special data such as on ethnic origin, race, physical or mental health or condition, religious beliefs, relationship status, criminal records, and children.

Section 5. Protection of Property Rights

Real Property

Qatar's property rights and ownership are governed by various laws, decrees, and resolutions. Law 16/2018 allows foreign investors full property ownership in nine zones and usufructuary rights for up to 99 years in 16 other zones. Foreigners can own villas in residential complexes and retail outlets in specific commercial complexes. Cabinet Resolution 28/2020 established the Office for Non-Qatari Real Estate Ownership to facilitate foreign ownership procedures. Non-Qatari property owners may receive residency permits, depending on property value and location, with a minimum 90-day stay requirement applying to certain categories. Law 6/2014 requires non-Qatari real estate developers to have at least 10 years of experience and be headquartered in Qatar. Law 5/2024 replaces Law 14/1964 on real estate registration and establishes an electronic registration system among other changes.

The Qatari government enforces property leasehold rights through Rent Law 4/2008, which protects lessees from rent increases during the lease period and preserves lease validity even if property ownership changes. Law 6/2022 established the Rental Dispute Settlement Committee, chaired by a judge, to enforce these regulations and issue binding decisions on rental disputes. Law 16/2021 governs the mortgaging of movable assets, introducing floating mortgages, debt subordination, and contractual enforcement. The Ministry of Municipality manages records related to real estate transactions, maintaining a reliable electronic database of encumbrances, liens, mortgages, and restrictions. Amiri Decree 52/2020 ratifies the 2001 Cape Town Convention on International Interests in Mobile Equipment and the Aircraft Protocol, reducing transactional risks and increasing commercial predictability for aircraft purchases and financing.

Intellectual Property

Qatar is not listed in United States Trade Representative's (USTR) Special 301 Report. Qatar's intellectual property (IP) legal regime is robust and includes legislation protecting different IP rights. Key laws include the Trademark and Copyright Law 7/2002, Protection of Trade Secrets

and Protection of Layout Design Law 5/2005, Patent Law 30/2006, and Protection of Industrial Designs and Models Law 10/2020. Qatar has signed many international IP treaties, ensuring their implementation through local laws. These laws grant the same rights to foreign applicants as Qatari nationals, provided their home country offers reciprocal treatment.

Intellectual property owners can apply for IP rights at MOCI, which oversees commercial registration and IP legislation and regulations. The IP Protection Department within MOCI handles,

- Trademarks,
- Copyrights,
- Patents, and
- Industrial designs.

The periods of validity for different types of registered IP are as follows:

- *Patents*: Valid for 20 years from the date of filing.
 - The Ministry of Public Health requires registration of all imported pharmaceutical products and rejects unauthorized copies of patented products. Qatar recognizes pre-existing GCC patents on pharmaceuticals.
 - The GCC Patent Office (GCCPO) based in Riyadh stopped accepting new filings in January 2021, requiring separate applications for each member country. In 2023, the GCCPO resumed operations, handling the national patent applications for requesting GCC countries, including Qatar.
- *Copyrights*: Protected for the life of the author plus 50 years after death.
 - Failure to register at MOCI does not affect protection. Qatar adheres to the Bern and Paris Conventions, protecting unpublished works. The IP Protection Department works with law enforcement authorities to prosecute unlicensed video and software resellers.

- *Trademarks*: Valid for 10 years, renewable indefinitely; unused trademarks for five consecutive years are subject to cancellation.
 - Qatar enacted the GCC's Common Trademark Law via Law 7/2014.
- *Industrial Designs*: Valid for five years from submission, renewable twice.
 - Covers visual design rather than functional or technical aspects.

Law 17/2011 forbids the importation of products infringing on IP rights in Qatar and obligates the General Authority of Customs to prevent their entry. IP rights holders can block the release of infringing products with sufficient evidence. The General Authority of Customs uses an electronic system accredited by the World Customs Organization to detect and limit counterfeit goods.

The Qatari Penal Code imposes hefty fines and prison terms for,

- Counterfeiting,
- Imitating,
- Fraudulently affixing,
- Selling products,
- Offering services of a registered trademark, or other IP violations.

The General Authority of Customs, MOCI Consumer Protection Department, IP Protection Department, and the Ministry of Interior (MOI) conduct surveys and raids and seize and destroy counterfeit products.

Qatar is a member of the WTO and the World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO) and is signatory to several WIPO treaties. For additional information on national laws and local IP offices, please see [WIPO's country profiles](#).

For assistance with IP protections and enforcement claims in Qatar, consult the list of local attorneys on the [U.S. Embassy Doha website](#).

Additional Resources for Rights Holders

U.S. Patent & Trademark Office

Aisha Y. Salem-Howey, Intellectual Property Attaché for the Middle East and North Africa

aisha.salem-howey@trade.gov

[uspto.gov](https://www.uspto.gov)

Section 6. Financial Sector

Capital Markets and Portfolio Investment

The Government of Qatar has permitted foreign portfolio investment since 2005. Qatar generally allows free flow of capital for foreign investors, though some restrictions apply in specific sectors and financial transactions. The Qatar Central Bank (QCB) adheres to conservative policies to maintain a stable banking sector. QCB respects IMF Article VIII and does not restrict payments or transfers for international transactions. Under QCB guidelines, banks operating in Qatar give priority to Qataris and public development projects in their financing operations. According to the 2024 official government budget release, the Qatari government held \$100.2 billion in external debt at the end of 2022.

The Qatar Stock Exchange (QSE), founded in 1997 and comprising 52 listed companies, is a member of the World Federation of Exchanges. Existing legislation allows full foreign ownership of Qatari companies listed on the QSE. In 2021, Qatar's cabinet approved a draft legislation allowing non-Qataris full ownership of capital in domestic banks, however, this legislation has not yet been implemented. Foreign portfolio investment in national oil and gas companies or companies with the right to explore national resources cannot exceed 49 percent.

Almost all import transactions require standard letters of credit from local banks and their correspondent banks in the exporting countries. Financial institutions extend credit facilities to local and foreign investors within standard international banking practices. Creditors typically require foreign investors produce a letter of guarantee from their local sponsor or equity partner. Banks usually refrain from extending credit facilities to single customers exceeding 20

percent of the bank's capital and reserves. QCB does not allow cross-sharing arrangements among banks. Per a February 2022 circular, QCB requires banks to maintain a credit to deposit ratio of 100 percent for issuance and borrowing with three years or above maturity, 50 percent for two years, and 25 percent for one year maturity.

Money and Banking System

Qatar has a comprehensive banking sector that offers both conventional and Shariah-compliant products and services with a bank account penetration of around 82 percent. The country's banking sector is composed of 17 banks, nine of which are Qatari banks, and the remaining eight are foreign financial institutions. The industry is dominated by government-owned Qatar National Bank (QNB), which enjoys over 50 percent of domestic market share in total assets, loans, and deposits with smaller lenders competing for remaining opportunities. Foreign banks registered under QCB are authorized to establish branches and conduct operations within the country, while banks under Qatar Financial Centre are restricted from doing so.

Qatari banks are well capitalized with a non-performing loans ratio of 3.5 percent in 2024. The Government of Qatar has always supported its banking sector where necessary and is expected to continue to do so given the country's substantial reserves. QCB is the primary regulator of the financial sector in the country and governs both conventional and Shariah-compliant institutions. According to QCB data, total domestic assets reached \$549 billion in 2024.

Foreign Exchange and Remittances

Foreign Exchange

Qatar generally does not restrict the transfer of funds abroad by foreign investors. Foreign investors are free to convert and transfer funds, capital, and profits associated with an investment, provided it does not involve money laundering activities. Due to minimal demand for the Qatari riyal outside of Qatar, and the national economy's dependence on gas and oil revenues priced in U.S. dollars in international markets, the government has pegged the riyal to the U.S. dollar. The official peg is \$1 per 3.64 Qatari riyals, as set by the government in June 1980 and reaffirmed by Amiri decree 34/2001.

Remittance Policies

Qatar neither delays remittance of foreign investment returns nor restricts the transfer of funds associated with an investment. These include:

- Return on dividends,
- Return on capital,
- Interest and principal payments on private foreign debt,
- Lease payments,
- Royalties,
- Management fees,
- Proceeds generated from sale or liquidation,
- Sums garnered from settlements and disputes, and
- Compensation from expropriation to financial institutions outside Qatar.

Per Law 20/2019 on Combating Money Laundering and Terrorism Financing, QCB requires financial institutions to apply due diligence before establishing business relationships, carrying out financial transactions, and performing wire transfers. Executive regulations for this law stipulate originator information should be secured when a wire transfer exceeds 3,500 Qatari riyals (\$962). Similarly, due diligence is required when a customer completes occasional transactions in a single operation or several linked operations exceeding 50,000 Qatari riyals (\$13,736). In similar efforts to combat money laundering, per Law 20/2019 and its subsequent Cabinet Resolution 41/2019, travelers to or from Qatar are required to complete a declaration form upon entry or departure if carrying cash, precious metals, financial instruments, or jewelry valued at 50,000 Qatari riyals or more (\$13,736). Law 4/2022 regulates the use of cash in the domestic market and additionally restricts cash transactions exceeding 50,000 Qatari riyals in value (\$13,736).

Sovereign Wealth Funds

QIA was established in 2005 and is chaired by the QCB Governor. The fund does not publicly disclose the size of its investments, but the Sovereign Wealth Fund Institute estimates their assets under management to be \$526 billion. According to QIA's public portfolio, the fund pursues direct investments in:

- Luxury brands,
- Prime real estate,
- Banks,
- As well as healthcare,
- Technology, and
- Infrastructure investments.

QIA is a member of the International Forum of Sovereign Wealth Funds. QIA has expressed its support for the Santiago Principles.

The fund has subsidiaries that invest locally and globally in sports, hospitality, and real estate development. In 2015, QIA opened an office in New York City. In May 2025, the fund pledged to invest \$500 billion in the U.S. economy over the next decade. QIA's real estate subsidiary, Qatari Diar, has operated an office in Washington since 2014.

Section 7. State-owned Enterprises

The State Audit Bureau oversees state-owned enterprises (SOEs), many of which operate as monopolies or hold exclusive rights in various economic sectors. Despite the dominance of SOEs, the government supports the local private sector, encouraging small and medium-sized enterprise development as part of its National Vision 2030. The private sector is favored in local contract bids and receives favorable financing terms from local banks. Major SOEs in Qatar include:

Energy:

- QatarEnergy: Wholly owned by the Government of Qatar. Non-Qataris can invest in companies partially owned by QatarEnergy that are publicly listed, such as Industries Qatar. In these cases, foreign ownership is typically capped at 49 percent, and individual limits may apply. In 2022 and 2023, select energy subsidiaries were allowed 100 percent foreign ownership.
- Qatar General Electricity and Water Corporation (Kahramaa): The sole utility provider, majority-owned by Qatari government entities. The Qatar Electricity and Water Company, established in 2001, sells desalinated water and electricity to Kahramaa. Other privatization efforts included the Ras Laffan Power Company, 55 percent owned by a U.S. company, and new public-private companies providing water treatment.

Aerospace:

- Qatar Airways: The national carrier, wholly owned by the state.

Services:

- Qatar General Postal Corporation: A state-owned postal company. Competing courier companies include Aramex, DHL Express, and FedEx Express.

Information and Communication:

- Ooredoo Group: A Qatar-based multinational telecommunications company founded in 2013. Ooredoo Qatar dominates the domestic cell and landline markets and is 68 percent owned by Qatari government entities. It is listed on the Qatari Stock Exchange, with remaining shares open to foreign investment.
- Vodafone Qatar: Qatar's only other telecommunications operator, after Ooredoo. Qatari government entities, primarily Qatar Foundation, own 91 percent of its shares, making it majority government owned. It is also listed on the Qatar Stock Exchange, with remaining shares open to foreign investors.

Qatari SOEs adhere to their own corporate governance codes and are not required to adhere to OECD Guidelines on Corporate Governance but operate under close government oversight. Investment disputes are reviewed by the appropriate sector regulator, such as the CRA for the ICT sector. Some SOEs publish online corporate governance reports to encourage transparency, but there is no general framework for all Qatari SOEs. SOEs listed on the stock exchange must publish financial statements at least 15 days before annual general meetings in two local newspapers (in Arabic and English) and on their websites.

Several Qatari SOEs compete internationally. For example, QatarEnergy is a competitive international energy investor, partnering with international energy giants. In the United States, QatarEnergy has a majority stake in the Golden Pass LNG terminal with ExxonMobil and in the Golden Triangle polymers plant with Chevron Phillips Chemical. Ooredoo Group has stakes in 10 markets across West Asia, North Africa, and Southeast Asia.

Privatization Program

There is no ongoing official privatization program for major SOEs.

Section 8. Corruption

Qatari law imposes criminal penalties to combat corruption and misuse of public money by public officials, and the government actively implements these laws. Law 22/2015, amending provisions to the Penal Code (Law 11/2004), imposes hefty penalties for corrupt officials. Decree 6/2015 restructured the Administrative Control and Transparency Authority (ACTA), granting it juridical responsibility, a budget, and direct affiliation with the Amir's office. The authority is responsible for preventing corruption, investigating complaints, and promoting transparency. The State Audit Bureau also oversees public financial management.

Qatar has laws and regulations to counter conflicts of interest in government procurement and awarding contracts. Law 11/2016 grants the State Audit Bureau more financial authority and independence to publish parts of its findings (provided that confidential information is removed), a power it did not previously hold. Individuals convicted of embezzlement are subject to prison terms of no less than five and up to ten years. Law 24/2015 (Public

Procurement Law) sets rules for a fair and transparent procurement processes, prohibiting public officials from having direct or indirect interests in government-awarded contracts. Per Law 17/2024, introducing amendments to the Law 24/2015 on Regulating Tenders and Auctions, some government entities, including the Qatar Armed Forces, QatarEnergy, and Qatar Investment Authority, are exempted from Law 24/2015 and maintain separate tendering procedures. The law also includes details about how bids are assessed and processed by government committees.

Qatar's Military Service Law 31/2006 prohibits a military service officer from accepting gifts or gratuitous payments. The current Penal Code (Law 11/2004) governs corruption regulations and stipulates individuals convicted of bribery may be sentenced to up to ten years in prison. The Qatar State Security Bureau and the Office of the Public Prosecutor handle investigations of alleged corruption charges, while the Criminal Court makes final judgments. Qatar's government does not explicitly require private companies to establish internal codes of conduct prohibiting bribery of public officials, but it encourages ethical business practices through its anti-corruption laws and regulatory frameworks. The Qatar Financial Centre (QFC) Regulations and the Qatar Stock Exchange Corporate Governance Code set compliance and governance expectations for businesses, especially those operating in regulated sectors.

Corruption in Qatar does not generally affect the conduct of business, although the power of personal connections plays a significant role in the business culture. In 2024, Transparency International ranked Qatar as the third least corrupt country in West Asia and North Africa, following the UAE and Israel, and 40th out of 180 countries. Qatar is a signatory to the United Nations Convention against Corruption (UNCAC), which it ratified in 2007. However, Qatar is not a signatory to the OECD Anti-Bribery Convention (Convention on Combating Bribery of Foreign Public Officials in International Business Transactions), which primarily targets corruption involving foreign public officials in international trade and investment. At the regional level, Qatar is a member of the Arab Anti-Corruption and Integrity Network (ACINET), which promotes transparency and integrity in public and private sectors across Arab countries.

Qatar regulates NGOs under government oversight, governed by the Ministry of Social Development and Family, with no specific legal protections for those investigating corruption.

Anti-corruption efforts are primarily led by state institutions, and independent NGOs focused on corruption are limited. Despite these efforts, some American businesses cite a lack of transparency in government procurement and customs as recurring issues when operating in the Qatari market. U.S. investors and Qatari nationals that are agents of U.S. firms are also subject to the provisions of the U.S. Foreign Corrupt Practices Act.

Resources to Report Corruption

The Administrative Control and Transparency Authority is responsible for receiving transparency-related complaints within the public sector:

Administrative Control and Transparency Authority

Al Bida St., Al Dafna, Doha, PO Box: 25558

974 44305220, +974 44305222, and +974 44069909

info@acta.gov.qa

To file complaints, visit: acta.gov.qa/en/acta-complaints

Section 9. Political and Security Environment

Qatar is a politically stable country with very low rates of crime. There are no political parties, labor unions, or organized domestic political opposition. The U.S. government assesses Qatar as a low to medium risk country for terrorism, with potential threats primarily from transnational actors. Crime and civil unrest are rare. Qatar does not have a history of politically motivated violence or civil disturbance, damage to investment projects, and/or installations, and is not growing increasingly politicized or insecure.

The State Department invites U.S. visitors to Qatar to enroll in its [Smart Traveler Enrollment Program](#) to receive real time updates on safety conditions in Qatar. Please monitor these updates and State Department social media accounts for up-to-date security guidance.

Section 10. Labor Policies and Practices

Qatar has one of the world's highest migrant workers to citizens population ratios, with foreigners making up nearly 90 percent of the country's population. Qatar's resident population is estimated at 3.7 million as of November 2024, quadrupling over the past two decades. Qatari citizens are estimated to constitute 11 percent of the total population. Qatar's labor force consists primarily of expatriate workers, the largest group of which comes from the Indian sub-continent. Males make up around 72 percent of the population. As of 2023, about 63.5 percent of women aged 15 years and above were economically active, compared to 95 percent of men. Qatar's unemployment rates are among the lowest globally, with a 0.1 percent unemployment rate as of 2023, because residency is largely employment-based. Over three-quarters of employed Qatari citizens work for the government.

The MOL regulates the recruitment of expatriate labor. Law 14/2004, as amended by Laws 1/2015, 13/2018, and 17/2020, largely governs employment in Qatar and allows the terminating party to terminate employment without providing reasons. The law requires employers to pay employees owed wages and other benefits in full to employees who have performed expected work duties during the notice period, which varies based on years of employment. English common law governs companies registered with QFC, and labor issues are administered by QFC's Regulation 10/2006. Local courts handle disputes between workers and employers, but the process is widely regarded as inefficient. To speed up labor dispute resolution, the government established Labor Disputes Settlement Committees (LDRCs) in 2018 headed by a judge and two representatives from MOL. In 2022, the Cabinet issued a decision to increase the number of LDRCs from three to five and distribute them geographically for better accessibility to workers.

Qatar is a member of the International Labor Organization (ILO) and maintains its labor law meets ILO minimum requirements. In 2018, the ILO opened a Doha office to work alongside the government in combating labor violations. The Cabinet extended the mandate of the ILO office in Qatar until 2028. The law does not provide for the rights of workers to form and join independent unions, conduct legal strikes, and bargain collectively. However, according to an

agreement between MOL and the ILO, joint worker committees including 50-50 representation of workers and employers exist in a small number of cases for medium to large-sized companies. Law 12/2004 on Private Associations and Foundations and subsequent regulations grant Qatari citizens the right to form workers' committees in private enterprises with more than 100 Qatari citizen workers. Qatari citizens employed in the private sector also have the right to participate in approved strikes. Regardless of nationality, individuals working in the public sector are prohibited from joining unions.

Law 17/2020 sets the non-discriminatory minimum basic wage for workers, including domestic workers, at 1000 Qatari riyals (approx. \$275) per month and 800 Qatari riyals (approx. \$220) for lodging and meals if not provided by the employer. To combat the problem of late and unpaid wages, the government issued Law 1/2015, amending specific provisions of Law 14/2004 on wage protection and mandating electronic payment to all employees subject to the local labor law. The government requires all Private Sector employers to open bank accounts for their employees and pay wages electronically through a system subject to audits by an inspection division at the MOL. This requirement, however, does not apply to domestic workers. Employers who fail to pay their workers face penalties up to \$2,747 per case and possible prison sentences of a maximum of one year. The system currently applies to over 1.4 million workers.

To eliminate forced labor, the government issued Law 19/2020, enabling employees to switch employers without requiring the employer's permission. This legislation complemented Law 13/2018, allowing workers covered by the law to leave the country without requiring exit permits. Law 14/2004 also prohibits employers' withholding of workers' passports and dictates penalties for transgressors. To protect workers from fraudulent employment contracts, MOI established the Qatar Visa Centers to simplify residency procedures for expatriate workers. These centers facilitate biometric enrollment, medical records verification, and work contracts before contracted workers enter Qatar.

The law allows long-term residents to apply for citizenship after 25 consecutive years, but applications are capped at 50 per year and are rarely approved. In March 2024, the government-owned Qatar Manpower Solutions Co. (Jusour) announced a five-year renewable

residency visa program for talented individuals and entrepreneurs, called the “Mustaqel Visas,” meaning the “independent visa” (see [eligibility requirements and the online application](#)).

Section 11. U.S. International Development Finance Corporation (DFC) and Other Investment Insurance or Development Finance Programs

DFC does not maintain a presence in Qatar, and there is no existing investment guaranty or investment incentive agreement between Qatar and the United States. Qatar is a member of the World Bank’s Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency.

Section 12. Contact for More Information

U.S. Embassy, Doha
Al Luqta District
22nd February Street
P.O. Box 2399
Doha, Qatar
Phone Number: +974-4496-6000
[Contact Us](#)